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# 7-Night Caribbean on Norwegian Aura: Hosted Group for Solo Cruisers

*Norwegian Aura · 7 Nights from Miami*

*October 14 to 21, 2028 · A Maulsby Travel Co. hosted group*



*Hosted* **GROUP CRUISE** *for Solo Cruisers!*

EXPERIENCE **NCL'S NEWEST SHIP!**

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- ST THOMAS**  
U.S. VIRGIN ISLANDS
- TORTOLA**  
BRITISH VIRGIN ISLANDS
- GREAT STIRRUP CAY**  
BAHAMAS

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PRICES SUBJECT TO CHANGE UNTIL BOOKING IS MADE. | Must book with Maulsby Travel Co. to participate.

The Maulsby Travel Co. flyer for this cruise: Hosted Group Cruise for Solo Cruisers on Norwegian Aura, October 14 to 21, 2028, a 7-night Caribbean cruise from Miami calling at Puerto Plata (Dominican Republic), St Thomas (U.S. Virgin Islands), Tortola (British Virgin Islands) and Great Stirrup Cay (Bahamas). Solo pricing on the flyer: Solo

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Studio \$1,599, Ocean View \$2,279, Balcony \$2,669. The ship on the flyer  
is an illustration. Flyer courtesy Mulsby Travel Co.

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**

Group organized by **Mulsby Travel Co.** · Booking: **Tina Mulsby**

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## Welcome

*Made for the solo cruiser who has booked this sailing, or is thinking about it, and wants one plain read on the week: the new ship, the four stops, the group, and what to check before you go.*

This pack is about one cruise: **Norwegian Aura**, sailing 7 nights round trip from **Miami, Saturday October 14 to Saturday October 21, 2028**. She calls at **Puerto Plata (Dominican Republic), St. Thomas (U.S. Virgin Islands), Tortola (British Virgin Islands) and Great Stirrup Cay (Bahamas)**, with a sea day after Miami and another before Great Stirrup Cay.

It's a **hosted group cruise for solo cruisers**, organized by **Maulsby Travel Co.** The flyer lists what the group includes: a dedicated group host, daily group dining, group shore excursion options, meetups and activities, and a private group chat before and during the cruise. **To be part of the group you have to book through Maulsby Travel Co.** That's on the flyer, and it matters: a cabin booked somewhere else is on the same ship but not in the group.

**Booking questions go to Tina Maulsby:** [tina@maulsbytravel.com](mailto:tina@maulsbytravel.com) or 910-528-5077. She can tell you what your group fare includes, who your host is, and how the group chat works.

### A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

Nobody has sailed Norwegian Aura yet. She's still being built as I write this in October 2026, and her first cruise is planned for May 2027. So nothing in this pack about the ship comes from being aboard. It comes from what Norwegian Cruise Line has published: its press releases, its deck plans, and its policy pages. Port details come from government and port sources where I could find them, and from travel sites where I couldn't, and the sources note at the end says which is which.

Two years is a long time in cruising. Venues get renamed, prices change, and port schedules move. **Where this pack gives a number, treat it as "this is what it was in 2026" and check it again before you sail.** If anything here disagrees with what Tina or your host tells you, go with them.

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It is calm by design. No urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent: no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. (See our **affiliate disclosure**.)

**A note on the season.** Mid-October is still hurricane season. NOAA's National Hurricane Center says the Atlantic season runs June 1 to November 30, with most activity between mid-August and mid-October. Your week sits at the end of that busy stretch. A storm can change a port or the order of the days, so travel insurance is worth having. See **Section 7**.

**Includes an Emergency Contacts section** with a fillable handoff card to leave with one trusted person at home, and the numbers for this itinerary. The companion app keeps it on your phone, and it works offline once it's loaded.

If this is your first time sailing solo, you won't be the only one in this group. The **solo cruising stories on this site** are worth a read before you go.

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## At a Glance

|                    |                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ship               | Norwegian Aura. NCL's newest ship when she enters service in 2027                                                                                         |
| Cruise line        | Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)                                                                                                                               |
| Class              | Prima Plus (NCL's August 2026 announcement; earlier releases said Prima class). Her older Prima Plus sisters are <b>Norwegian Aqua</b> and Norwegian Luna |
| Size (NCL figures) | About 170,000 gross tons · almost 1,130 feet long · 3,879 guests at two to a cabin · 1,976 staterooms, 159 of them in The Haven                           |
| Built by           | Fincantieri, at its Monfalcone shipyard in Italy. She was floated out April 16, 2026                                                                      |
| First cruise       | May 21, 2027, Trieste to Barcelona. Miami homeport from June 10, 2027                                                                                     |

|                                 |                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Godmother</b>                | Not announced as of October 2026                                                                                                     |
| <b>Departure port</b>           | Miami (PortMiami), NCL's terminal                                                                                                    |
| <b>Itinerary</b>                | 7 nights · Eastern Caribbean round trip                                                                                              |
| <b>Group</b>                    | Hosted group for solo cruisers, organized by Maulsby Travel Co.                                                                      |
| <b>Group rates on the flyer</b> | Solo Studio \$1,599 · Ocean View \$2,279 · Balcony \$2,669. The flyer says prices can change until you book. Confirm yours with Tina |
| <b>Currency aboard</b>          | US dollar                                                                                                                            |

## Ports of call

The schedule below is from cruise booking sites (iCruise and CruiseWeb) for this exact sailing. NCL's own site hadn't published per-day times for October 2028 when this was written. **Check your times in the NCL app before you sail.**

1. **Miami, Florida.** Board Saturday October 14. Ship leaves 4:00 PM
2. **At sea.** Sunday October 15
3. **Puerto Plata, Dominican Republic.** Monday October 16, 7:00 AM to 3:00 PM
4. **St. Thomas, U.S. Virgin Islands.** Tuesday October 17, 10:00 AM to 6:00 PM
5. **Tortola, British Virgin Islands.** Wednesday October 18, 7:00 AM to 2:00 PM
6. **At sea.** Thursday October 19
7. **Great Stirrup Cay, Bahamas.** Friday October 20, 10:00 AM to 6:00 PM
8. **Miami.** Arrive Saturday October 21, 7:00 AM

**All-aboard is one hour before the ship leaves.** That's NCL's own rule (its boarding-times FAQ). So: 2:00 PM in Puerto Plata, 5:00 PM in St. Thomas, **1:00 PM in Tortola**, and 5:00 PM at Great Stirrup Cay. Tortola is the short day. Plan it that way.

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## Section 1 — Your Ship: Norwegian Aura

### A new ship, about a year and a half old when you board

Norwegian Aura is the largest ship NCL has ordered so far, and its own announcement in January 2026 put her at about 170,000 gross tons, almost 1,130 feet long, carrying 3,879 guests at two to a cabin. Gross tonnage is a measure of the ship's enclosed volume, not her weight, so read it as “how much room there is,” not “how heavy she is.” If you want to see how she compares with other ships, the **Ship Size Atlas** lines them up side by side.

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She's being built by Fincantieri at Monfalcone, Italy, and was floated out there on April 16, 2026. Her first sailing is planned for May 21, 2027, from Trieste to Barcelona, and she's due to start sailing from Miami on June 10, 2027. By your October 2028 cruise she'll have about a year and a half of sailing behind her, so the crew will know the ship and the early kinks should be worked out.

NCL calls her a **Prima Plus** ship in its August 2026 announcement. Her older sisters in that class are **Norwegian Aqua** (2025) and **Norwegian Luna** (2026). If you've sailed one of them, much of Aura will feel familiar.

**What NCL hasn't announced yet:** her godmother, her crew count, and an exact delivery date. Some travel sites print figures for these. This pack doesn't, because NCL hasn't.

### What's on board (as NCL has announced it)

- **Ocean Heights, Decks 18 to 21.** This is the big outdoor play area. NCL lists the **Eclipse Racers** (two side-by-side mat-racing waterslides, over 400 feet long), **Aura Free Fall** (the floor drops out and you fall 250 feet of slide), **The Wave** (a raft slide for up to four people), **The Drop** (a dry slide that runs ten decks, from Deck 18 down to Deck 8), a ropes course, a climbing wall, mini golf, and cabanas that hang out over the adults-only Vibe Beach Club. NCL hasn't said which of these carry a fee. Check the NCL app once you can see your sailing's details.
- **Ocean Boulevard, Deck 8.** The outdoor walkway that wraps the ship, with hot tubs, a bar and seating. NCL says it's 11% longer on Aura than on Aqua and Luna. On a sea day it's a good place to sit with coffee and watch the water.
- **Vibe Beach Club.** Adults only. NCL says it's 15% larger than the ones on Aqua and Luna. On other NCL ships Vibe is sold as a separate pass. NCL hasn't published Aura's price.
- **Mandara Spa.** Two decks, with a Thermal Suite that NCL calls the most expansive at sea, and a Sensory Rain Pool that it calls the first of its kind at sea. Those are NCL's claims, quoted as NCL's.
- **The Haven.** NCL's suite area with its own restaurant, bar, lounge, pool and sundeck. Aura has 159 Haven suites, more than any NCL ship before her.
- **Shows.** NCL announced *Whitney: A Celebration of Whitney Houston*, a 45-minute show in the Aura Theatre & Club, along with ILLUMINOX, The Vinyl Republic,

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Latin LIVE! and Aura FIRST NIGHT. **LunaTique** is adults-only and costs extra; NCL says it includes cocktails. Show schedules for October 2028 won't be out until close to sailing.

## Cabin choice: the solo calculation

The flyer has three prices. Here's what each one is.

- **Solo Studio at \$1,599.** NCL's own cabin for one person. On Aura, NCL's deck plans list the Solo Studio at **94 square feet, on Decks 12 and 13**, with a full-size bed, and access to the **Studio Lounge**, which is only for Studio guests. NCL says Studios are "specifically designed and priced for solo travelers." The Studio Lounge is where solo cruisers find each other, apart from anything the group plans. NCL hasn't published how many Studios Aura has.
- **Ocean View at \$2,279.** A window. That's \$680 more than the Studio. You get daylight and more room.
- **Balcony at \$2,669.** Your own outdoor space. That's \$390 more than Ocean View. On a Caribbean week with two sea days, a balcony gets a lot of use.

Prices are from the flyer and can change until you book. **Ask Tina what each fare includes**, because NCL's package offers change. In November 2025 NCL replaced its "More at Sea" package with one called "Free at Sea" for new bookings. What Free at Sea includes in 2028 is something to confirm with her, not something to assume. Once you've picked a cabin, the **cabin organization guide** helps with small-space living.

## Dining

NCL says Aura has 22 places to eat and drink. Here's how they split, from NCL's August 2026 announcement.

### Included with your fare:

- **Hudson's.** The main dining room, with what NCL calls 270-degree ocean views.
- **The Panorama Room, Deck 6.** NCL calls it "a completely reimagined complimentary dining experience." It's new, so there's no page for it on this site yet.

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- **Indulge Food Hall.** Nine counters, including Mexican food inspired by Los Lobos, a new Middle Eastern counter, Q Texas Smokehouse, Planterie and Nudls. Good for a solo lunch: walk up, order, sit anywhere.
  - **Surfside Café.** The buffet. NCL says it's bigger on Aura and runs along both sides of the ship.
  - **The Local Bar & Grill.** Pub food nearly all day.

**Specialty restaurants (extra charge, or part of a dining package):**

- **Tamara, Deck 8.** NCL's first Indian specialty restaurant. New on Aura.
- **Cagney's Steakhouse, Le Bistro** (Deck 7), **Sukhothai** (Thai, Deck 7), **Palomar** and **Onda by Scarpetta** (both Deck 8), **Hasuki** (hibachi) and **Nama** (sushi).

NCL hasn't published Aura's specialty prices. If your fare includes specialty meals, book them as soon as NCL opens reservations for your sailing.

**Drinks.** Whether drinks are included depends on your fare. Ask Tina. If you're buying a package, **put your own numbers into the drink calculator**. It's set up for NCL, and it shows whether a package pays off for the way you actually drink.

## Getting online

NCL sells Wi-Fi packages, and some fares include some Wi-Fi. The **internet at sea guide** explains how cruise Wi-Fi works and how to avoid roaming charges ashore.

For most people in this group:

- Use whatever Wi-Fi your fare includes, and don't expect to stream video.
  - In port, your own phone plan may work. Check with your carrier before you go (more in **Section 8**).
  - Send one short message a day to someone at home. See **Section 6**.
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## Section 2 — Day by Day

The times below come from cruise booking sites for this sailing. **Check them in the NCL app before you sail.** The departure time printed for each port is ship time. Before you walk off, check it again and set your watch to the ship.

***This is not your plan.** What follows is one possible shape of the week, not a schedule to keep. Only a few things on it are actually fixed: the muster drill, sailaway, the ship's arrival and all-aboard times in each port, and anything you have already booked. Everything else is a suggestion you are free to ignore, reorder, or sleep through. A day spent entirely on your balcony is not a day wasted, and nothing here is a commitment you have made to anyone.*

### Day 1 — Saturday, October 14 — Miami (embarkation)

**Terminal.** NCL's PortMiami terminal is at **1015 N. America Way**. NCL's driving directions say to put **1761 N. Cruise Blvd.** into your GPS, and to park in **Garage B**, which NCL runs. NCL hadn't said which terminal Aura uses when this was written; its other big ships use this one. **Your boarding documents will name the terminal. Check it.**

**Fly in the day before.** The ship leaves at 4:00 PM, and a same-day flight leaves no room for a delay. Friday October 13 is the sensible arrival day.

**The usual first afternoon:**

- **Before you leave home:** do NCL's online check-in and pick your arrival time.
- **Board and eat.** Cabins usually aren't ready right away. Lunch at **Surfside Café** or **Indulge Food Hall** passes the time.
- **Muster drill.** Required. Part of it is in the NCL app, and part is checking in at your assigned station.
- **4:00 PM, sailaway.** Your host will say where the group is meeting, in the group chat.
- **Evening.** The group's dinner plan comes from your host. If you're in a Studio, check the daily schedule in the app for a Studio Lounge get-together.

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**Keep in your carry-on:** your **passport**, all medications, a swimsuit, a change of clothes, a phone charger. Checked bags can take until evening to reach your cabin.

**Money aboard.** Your keycard is your room key and your charge card. Everything aboard is in US dollars.

## Day 2 — Sunday, October 15 — At sea

The first sea day. The ship is heading southeast toward the Dominican Republic.

**Some ideas, pick what suits you:**

- Coffee on **Ocean Boulevard** (Deck 8) early, before it gets busy.
- **Studio Lounge** if you're in a Studio.
- **Ocean Heights** (Decks 18 to 21) in the first hour it opens, when lines are short.
- The **spa's Thermal Suite**, if you've bought a pass.
- **Book specialty dinners** if you haven't.
- Whatever group activity your host plans.

## Day 3 — Monday, October 16 — Puerto Plata, Dominican Republic

**In port:** 7:00 AM to 3:00 PM. **All aboard 2:00 PM.**

**Which pier.** Puerto Plata has two cruise piers. **Amber Cove**, west of town, is used mostly by Carnival's lines. **Taino Bay** sits at the edge of the old town, and port listings put NCL's ships there. The Dominican government announced the first call of Aura's sister ship, Norwegian Aqua, at Taino Bay. **Nobody has published Aura's pier for 2028.** This pack assumes Taino Bay, but check the NCL app.

**If it's Taino Bay:** the old town is next door. Travel guides put the walk at 10 to 15 minutes.

**Things to know:**

- **Fortaleza San Felipe.** The Dominican tourism ministry describes it as a fort the Spanish built in the 16th century to defend the north coast.
- **The cable car up Mount Isabel de Torres** has been closed since June 2024 for lack of a safety certificate, according to Dominican news reports. A rebuild started

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in October 2026, and the target for reopening is early 2028. **Check before you plan on it.**

- **NCL's tours, with 2026 prices:** Ocean World Day Pass (adults from \$99.99, about 4½ hours, buffet lunch included) and Damajagua Waterfalls (adults from \$119.99, about 4 hours, minimum age 8, closed-toe shoes required). The waterfalls are a drive inland, so on a day with a 2:00 PM all-aboard a ship tour is the safe choice. NCL says it always waits for its own tours to get back before sailing.

**Money.** The Dominican peso is the local money. The tourism ministry says businesses in tourist areas take dollars, but at a worse rate than the banks. Small US bills are fine for a short day.

**Documents.** You need a passport. The Dominican Republic's entry page asks for **six months of validity** left on it. There was a temporary exception for US citizens, but it ran only through December 31, 2026. For October 2028, make sure your passport is good **through at least April 2029** unless the rule has changed. Cruise passengers don't fill out the e-ticket form.

**Emergency number:** 911.

**Pack for today:** passport, sunscreen, a hat, water shoes if you're doing the waterfalls, some small US bills.

Build your day in the **Port Day Planner**, and log it afterward in the **Port Logbook**. This site's page for the other Puerto Plata pier, **Amber Cove**, has more about the area.

## Day 4 — Tuesday, October 17 — St. Thomas, U.S. Virgin Islands



Charlotte Amalie, St. Thomas: colorful Danish colonial buildings cascading down the hillside above the harbor

**In port:** 10:00 AM to 6:00 PM. **All aboard 5:00 PM.**

**Which pier.** Ships dock at either **Havensight** or **Crown Bay**, both near downtown Charlotte Amalie. Local news reports of the West Indian Company's 2027 schedule put Aura at the **WICO dock at Havensight**. The 2028 schedule wasn't out when this was written.

**What it is.** A US territory. US dollars, and US phone plans work the way they do at home. **They drive on the left.**

**Things to know (2026 prices):**

- **Magens Bay.** The beach most people mean when they say St. Thomas. Entry is **\$7 for non-residents over 12** (the Magens Bay Authority's fee since October 2023). Taxis charge per person. A 2024 copy of the official rate card shows **\$15 for one person, \$12 each for two or more** between Magens Bay and Havensight.
- **St. John.** The public ferry from **Red Hook**, on the east end, runs every hour on the hour and takes about 20 minutes. The fare is **\$8.15 each way** (VI Department of Public Works). **Trunk Bay** in the national park charges \$5 for ages 16 and up. The ferry from downtown leaves at 10:00 AM, which is when the ship arrives, so Red

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Hook is the realistic route. Be back at Red Hook in time to make a 5:00 PM all-aboard. A ship tour is the no-worry way to do St. John.

- **Downtown.** Shopping on Main Street, and the old Danish buildings. The USVI tourism department says both piers are a short distance from downtown.

**Emergency number:** 911.

**Documents.** US citizens don't need a passport to visit the USVI, but you need one for the rest of this cruise, so carry it.

More on the **St. Thomas port page**.

## Day 5 — Wednesday, October 18 — Tortola, British Virgin Islands

**In port:** 7:00 AM to 2:00 PM. **All aboard 1:00 PM.** This is the short day.

**The pier.** Ships dock at the cruise pier in Road Town, the capital. CruiseMapper says the pier takes two large ships, and when a third is in, one anchors and runs tenders. Pier Park, the shopping and restaurant area, is right at the pier, and travel guides put the walk into Road Town at 10 to 15 minutes.

**What it is.** A British Overseas Territory that uses the US dollar.

**Things to know:**

- **Cane Garden Bay.** A beach on the north side. A 2026 travel guide puts the taxi at **\$10 to \$16 per person**, about 20 minutes each way. A good half day that leaves room before 1:00 PM.
- **The Baths, Virgin Gorda.** The big boulders and sea pools, on another island. **Don't try it on your own this day.** The public ferries work on paper, but one late boat means a missed ship. NCL sells a Virgin Gorda and The Baths tour, and NCL says it always waits for its own tours to get back before sailing.
- **Road Town.** Walkable from the pier.

**Emergency number:** 911 (the UK government's travel advice; it also lists 767 for sea rescue).

**Documents.** The BVI tourism board says a **passport** is required to enter and leave. Bring it.

More on the **Tortola port page**.

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## Day 6 — Thursday, October 19 — At sea

The second sea day, heading northwest toward the Bahamas. A good day for the spa, Ocean Heights, or a long lunch. It's also a good day to settle your onboard account in the app, so the last morning is quieter.

## Day 7 — Friday, October 20 — Great Stirrup Cay, Bahamas

**In port:** 10:00 AM to 6:00 PM. **All aboard 5:00 PM.**

**The pier.** NCL's private island now has a pier, so you **walk off the ship**. No tender boats. The first ship docked there on December 28, 2025.

**Free with your fare** (NCL's island page): the beaches, the food, a resort-style pool, and a kids' splash pad.

**Extra cost:**

- **Great Tides Waterpark.** It opened September 4, 2026. NCL says it's an extra cost, and that tickets and pricing "vary based on seasonality and availability." NCL lets booked guests reserve passes in the app up to two days before sailing. NCL hasn't published a price.
- **Vibe Shore Club** (adults only, a day pass), **cabanas**, and the **Silver Cove** villas.

**Paying.** NCL quotes a guest saying their room card worked on the island.

**Documents.** The Bahamas is a foreign country, so carry your passport.

**Emergency.** The ship's medical team and NCL's staff are on the island.

More on the **Great Stirrup Cay port page**.

## Day 8 — Saturday, October 21 — Miami (debarkation)

The ship is due in at 7:00 AM. NCL will tell you the night before how bags and walk-off times work. Usually you put checked bags outside your door the night before, and keep your passport, medications and a change of clothes with you.

**Flights home:** book a flight that leaves after midday. Getting off a big ship, through customs and to the airport takes time.

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## Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

### Now, when you book

- **Book through Maulsby Travel Co.** That's how you get into the group. Contact **Tina Maulsby** at [tina@maulsbytravel.com](mailto:tina@maulsbytravel.com) or 910-528-5077.
- **Ask Tina what your fare includes:** drinks, Wi-Fi, specialty dining, and whether gratuities are prepaid.
- **Check your passport.** For the Dominican Republic it should be valid through **at least April 2029**. Renew now if it isn't.
- **Buy travel insurance** soon after you book. It's hurricane season, and medical care aboard is billed to you.

### When NCL opens your reservation details

- **Specialty dining**, if your fare includes it or you plan to buy it.
- **Shore tours.** Damajagua in Puerto Plata and the Virgin Gorda tour from Tortola are the ones worth booking early.
- **Great Tides Waterpark**, if you want it. NCL lets you book passes up to two days before sailing.

### About a month before

- **Do NCL's online check-in** and choose an arrival time.
- **Fill in the handoff card** in **Section 6** and give it to one person at home.
- **Join the group chat**, if you haven't already.
- **Count down** with the **countdown tool**, if that helps.

### The week before

- **Check the hurricane outlook** at the National Hurricane Center ([nhc.noaa.gov](http://nhc.noaa.gov)).
- **Download your boarding documents** and keep a copy offline.
- **Pack.** See **Section 4**.

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## The day before, Friday October 13

- **Fly into Miami** and stay the night.
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## Section 4 — Packing List

This list fits a **mid-October Eastern Caribbean week**: hot days, warm nights, a real chance of showers, three port days, two sea days and an island day. NCL is a casual line. Evenings are relaxed, and NCL's own description of its new dining room says casual dress is as welcome as a suit jacket. For more, see the **packing lists**.

### Documents and money

- **Passport**, valid through at least April 2029
- A copy of your passport, kept somewhere else
- Your insurance policy and its emergency number, printed
- Two cards, kept in different places
- Some small US bills for taxis and tips ashore
- Your NCL boarding documents, printed and saved offline

### Carry-on

- All medications, in their original bottles
- Phone, charger, power bank
- Refillable water bottle
- Swimsuit
- A change of clothes
- Sunglasses, hat, sunscreen
- A light rain jacket

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## Daytime

- Swimsuits (more than one, since things dry slowly in humid air)
- A cover-up
- Light shirts and shorts
- One long-sleeved shirt for sun, and for bugs inland
- A light sweater for the air conditioning
- Insect repellent

## Evenings

- Casual-smart outfits for dinner
- One dressier outfit if you like to dress up

## Footwear

- Walking shoes
- **Closed-toe water shoes**, required for Damajagua Waterfalls
- Sandals or flip-flops

## Toiletries and health

- Prescriptions, plus a few days extra in case of delay
- Pain reliever, stomach medicine, and motion-sickness medicine if you use it
- Reef-safe sunscreen, after-sun lotion, lip balm with SPF

## Leave at home

- Valuable jewelry.
  - Before you pack an iron, a steamer or candles, check NCL's list of prohibited items.
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## Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

Prices here were checked in October 2026, for a cruise in October 2028. **Expect them to change.** Use them for planning, and check again at booking and before you sail. For your own total, the **cruise budget calculator** is set up for this.

### Usually in the fare

- Your cabin
- Meals at Hudson's, the Panorama Room, Indulge Food Hall, Surfside Café and The Local
- The main shows
- Pools, the gym, and the free parts of Ocean Heights
- Whatever your group fare adds. Ask Tina

### What might cost extra

| Item                       | What we know (2026)                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| NCL's daily service charge | \$20 per person per day (7 nights = \$140); \$25 in The Haven and suites. NCL's figure for bookings made from January 1, 2023                        |
| Drinks                     | Depends on your fare. Ask Tina, then run the <b>drink calculator</b>                                                                                 |
| Wi-Fi                      | Depends on your fare                                                                                                                                 |
| Specialty dining           | Prices for Aura not yet published                                                                                                                    |
| Puerto Plata tours (NCL)   | Ocean World from \$99.99 adult; Damajagua from \$119.99 adult                                                                                        |
| St. Thomas                 | Magens Bay \$7 entry plus taxi (\$15 one person, \$12 each for two or more, per a 2024 rate card); St. John ferry \$8.15 each way plus Trunk Bay \$5 |

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| Item                          | What we know (2026)                                                                          |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tortola</b>                | Cane Garden Bay taxi \$10 to \$16 per person each way; NCL's Virgin Gorda and The Baths tour |
| <b>Great Stirrup Cay</b>      | Waterpark, cabanas, Vibe Shore Club: prices not yet published                                |
| <b>LunaTique show</b>         | Extra; price not yet published                                                               |
| <b>Travel insurance</b>       | Depends on age and coverage                                                                  |
| <b>Hotel the night before</b> | Depends on Miami prices that weekend                                                         |

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## Tippling

NCL's service charge covers the crew in general. Many people also tip a little in cash for service that stood out. The **cruise tipping calculator** does the arithmetic, and **Cruise Tipping 2026** explains the custom.

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## Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Fill this in and give a copy to one person at home before you go.

## FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: \_\_\_\_\_  
 CABIN: \_\_\_\_\_  
 SHIP: Norwegian Aura  
 LINE: Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)  
 SAILING: October 14 – 21, 2028  
 FROM: Miami, Florida, USA  
 ITINERARY: Miami → at sea → Puerto Plata (DR) →  
 St. Thomas (USVI) → Tortola (BVI) →  
 at sea → Great Stirrup Cay (Bahamas) →  
 Miami  
 GROUP: Maulsby Travel Co. hosted solo group  
 Host: \_\_\_\_\_

## EMERGENCY (24/7):

US Citizens Abroad – State Dept OCS:  
 +1 (888) 407-4747 (from the US/Canada)  
 +1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)  
 Reach someone aboard – NCL:  
 +1 (833) 810-7963 (US/Canada)  
 +1 (321) 953-9006 (international)  
 (a paid call; have a card ready)  
 Booking – Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.:  
 910-528-5077  
 tina@maulsbytravel.com

## EMERGENCY NUMBERS ASHORE:

Miami, FL – 911  
 Puerto Plata, DR – 911  
 US Embassy Santo Domingo:  
 do.usembassy.gov  
 St. Thomas, USVI – 911 (US territory)  
 Tortola, BVI – 911; sea rescue 767  
 US Embassy Bridgetown covers  
 the BVI: bb.usembassy.gov  
 Great Stirrup Cay – ship's medical team on the island  
 US Embassy Nassau:  
 bs.usembassy.gov

## CRUISER MEDICAL:

Allergies: \_\_\_\_\_  
 Medications: \_\_\_\_\_  
 Conditions: \_\_\_\_\_  
 Insurance: \_\_\_\_\_ policy: \_\_\_\_\_

## WHERE IS THE SHIP:

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[cruisinginthewake.com/tools/ship-tracker.html](https://cruisinginthewake.com/tools/ship-tracker.html)

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## What the person at home should do

If they don't hear from you for a day or two:

1. **Don't panic.** Ship Wi-Fi is patchy. Silence usually means no signal.
2. **Call Tina** at Maulsby Travel Co. (910-528-5077). She booked you and can reach your host.
3. **To get a message to the ship**, call NCL's line for reaching guests aboard: +1 (833) 810-7963 from the US or Canada, +1 (321) 953-9006 from elsewhere. It's a paid call.
4. **If it's serious**, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services: +1 (888) 407-4747. It's free, it runs around the clock, and it works with cruise lines and embassies.
5. **To see where the ship is**, use the **ship tracker**.

The page on **reaching someone at sea** explains how all this works.

**Why no embassy phone numbers?** The embassy sites couldn't be read from where this pack was made, and a wrong emergency number is worse than none. Look up the numbers on the embassy sites above before you leave, and write them in.

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## Section 7 — Seasickness and October Weather

### Weather

Below are typical figures for October 14 to 21, worked out from five years of weather records (2020 to 2024) for each port. They're averages, not a forecast. The companion app shows a real forecast once your dates are about two weeks away.

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| Port              | Typical high | Typical low | Days with rain |
|-------------------|--------------|-------------|----------------|
| Miami             | 82°F         | 72°F        | 68%            |
| Puerto Plata      | 87°F         | 76°F        | 50%            |
| St. Thomas        | 84°F         | 81°F        | 52%            |
| Tortola           | 84°F         | 81°F        | 48%            |
| Great Stirrup Cay | 82°F         | 78°F        | 52%            |

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These come from Open-Meteo's historical weather records, at the grid point the records use for each port. For small islands like St. Thomas and Tortola that point sits over the water, which is why their night-time lows look so close to the highs.

**Wet days** means days with more than 1 mm of rain. Bring a light rain jacket.

**Hurricanes.** NOAA says the season runs to November 30, and most activity happens between mid-August and mid-October. If a storm threatens, the cruise line can change ports or the order of the days. It's their call, and it's made for safety. That's the main reason to carry travel insurance this week.

## Seasickness

Nobody can promise how your body will feel at sea. If you're prone to seasickness:

- **Pick a cabin low and in the middle of the ship**, where motion is least.
  - **Ask your doctor or pharmacist** about meclizine (Bonine), dimenhydrinate (Dramamine) or a prescription scopolamine patch, and try anything new at home first.
  - **Ginger and acupressure bands** help some people.
  - **Fresh air and a view of the horizon** help most people.
  - **The ship's medical center** can treat seasickness. It bills you, and most US health plans don't cover care at sea, so check yours.
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## Section 8 — Practical Logistics

### Phones

- **At sea:** use the ship's Wi-Fi, and turn off cellular data to avoid charges from the ship's network.
- **Puerto Plata and Tortola:** foreign countries. Some US plans include them and some charge a daily fee. **Check with your carrier before you go.**
- **St. Thomas:** a US territory, so most US plans work as they do at home.
- **Great Stirrup Cay:** don't count on a signal.

### Money

- **Aboard:** US dollars, charged to your keycard.
- **Puerto Plata:** pesos, though dollars are widely taken in tourist areas at a worse rate.
- **St. Thomas and Tortola:** US dollars.
- **Great Stirrup Cay:** your room card.

### Laundry

NCL's packing page says plainly: "Please note that laundry is not self-service." You can send clothes out through your cabin steward, for a charge. Packing a few things you can wash in the sink saves money.

### Smoking

NCL doesn't allow smoking in cabins or on balconies, and charges a \$250 cleaning fee if you do. Indoor public areas are smoke-free except the casino and cigar lounges.

### Accessibility

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If you use a wheelchair or a scooter, or need other help, tell Tina when you book so NCL can note it. Every port on this cruise is a docked port when things go to plan, so there are no tender boats on a normal day. At Tortola, if three ships are in, one has to tender. The **accessibility guide** on this site covers more.

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## Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

Your host will run the group's week, and the plan will come through the group chat. The flyer lists what's included:

- **A dedicated group host** aboard
- **Daily group dining**
- **Group shore excursion options**
- **Meetups and activities**
- **A private group chat**, before and during the cruise

So expect a sailaway meetup, a regular dinner time, and some group options in port.

**Nothing is required.** You can show up for every dinner or for one. Most hosted groups are made up of people who came alone, so nobody needs a reason to sit down.

**If you're shy:** go to one dinner. That's all it takes. Things grow from there.

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## Section 10 — Solo Cruising Considerations

Aura has NCL's solo cabins and the lounge that goes with them:

- **Solo Studios**, which NCL says are designed and priced for solo travelers.
- **The Studio Lounge** is for Studio guests only, with drinks and light snacks, and it's where solo cruisers meet.

- 
- **Indulge Food Hall and the buffet** are easy places to eat alone without asking for a table for one.
  - **Ocean Boulevard** has room to sit by the water on your own, with plenty of people around.

**Safety, the same as at home:** tell someone where you're going ashore, keep your drink in sight, and use the ship's tours if you'd rather not plan the day yourself.

The **solo cruising hub** has more from people who've done it.

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## Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise, the **first-cruise guide** goes deeper. A few things worth knowing ahead:

- **Cabins are small.** Even a balcony cabin is smaller than most hotel rooms.
- **The NCL app is how you run the week.** Download it and log in before you go.
- **Be back early.** Be back aboard before all-aboard time. If you're late on your own, the ship can leave without you. NCL says it always waits for its own tours.
- **You don't have to do everything.** The best part of a cruise is often the hour you didn't plan.

The **cruise duck tradition** is a small, friendly custom worth knowing about. If you like photos, the **cruise tech and photography guide** helps you pack the right gear.

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## Closing

This pack is a plain read on one week: a brand-new ship, four warm stops, and a group of people who came alone and don't have to stay that way. Check the numbers before you go, book through Maulsby Travel Co., and enjoy it.

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**Share or save.** The companion app has a share button. If someone you know is thinking about this cruise, send them the link.

**Soli Deo Gloria.** All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent: no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped you, that's the whole point.

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Last reviewed | 2026-10-05. Ship facts from NCL's releases of January, April, August and September 2026; sailing times from booking sites; port facts as noted below | How facts here are checked | Every fact in this pack is listed with its source in the pack's fact-check file. Ship facts come from Norwegian Cruise Line's own newsroom and website. The sailing's dates, port order and times come from two cruise booking sites (iCruise and CruiseWeb), because NCL's own site hadn't published per-day times for this sailing. Port facts come from government and port-authority sources where they could be read (the Dominican tourism ministry, the VI Department of Public Works, the National Park Service, the BVI tourism board, the UK government's travel advice, US Customs and Border Protection, NOAA) and from named travel sites where they couldn't. Weather averages were calculated from Open-Meteo's historical weather records. Where sources disagreed, the pack says so or leaves the number out. | Accessibility | This pack is written to read straight through on a screen reader: headings in order, small labeled tables, and links named for where they go. If something here is hard for you to use, that's a bug. Tell Tina and it'll get back to me. | Sources | Ports on this site: **Miami, Amber Cove, St. Thomas, Tortola, Great Stirrup Cay**. Ship: Norwegian Cruise Line newsroom (January 15, April 16, August 19 and September 15, 2026) and NCL's Aura deck plans, accommodations, dining and Haven pages; sister ship **Norwegian Aqua**. Venues: **Hudson's, Indulge Food Hall, Surfside Café, The Local, Cagney's, Le Bistro, Sukhothai, Palomar, Onda by Scarpetta, Hasuki, Nama, Studio Lounge, Vibe Beach Club**. Tools: **drink calculator, cruise budget calculator, cruise tipping calculator, port day planner, port logbook, ship tracker, ship size atlas**. Reference: **solo cruising hub, first-cruise guide, countdown, packing lists, internet at sea, reaching someone at sea, disability at sea**. Articles: **cruise cabin organization, Cruise Tipping 2026, cruise duck tradition, cruise tech and photography guide**. Cover: the Maulsby Travel Co. flyer for this sailing. |